

Teaching with Digital Humanities

Cynthia Heider, Public Digital Scholarship Librarian at Penn Libraries
heider@upenn.edu

Find these slides at <https://bit.ly/rdds-teaching-with-dh>

About Me

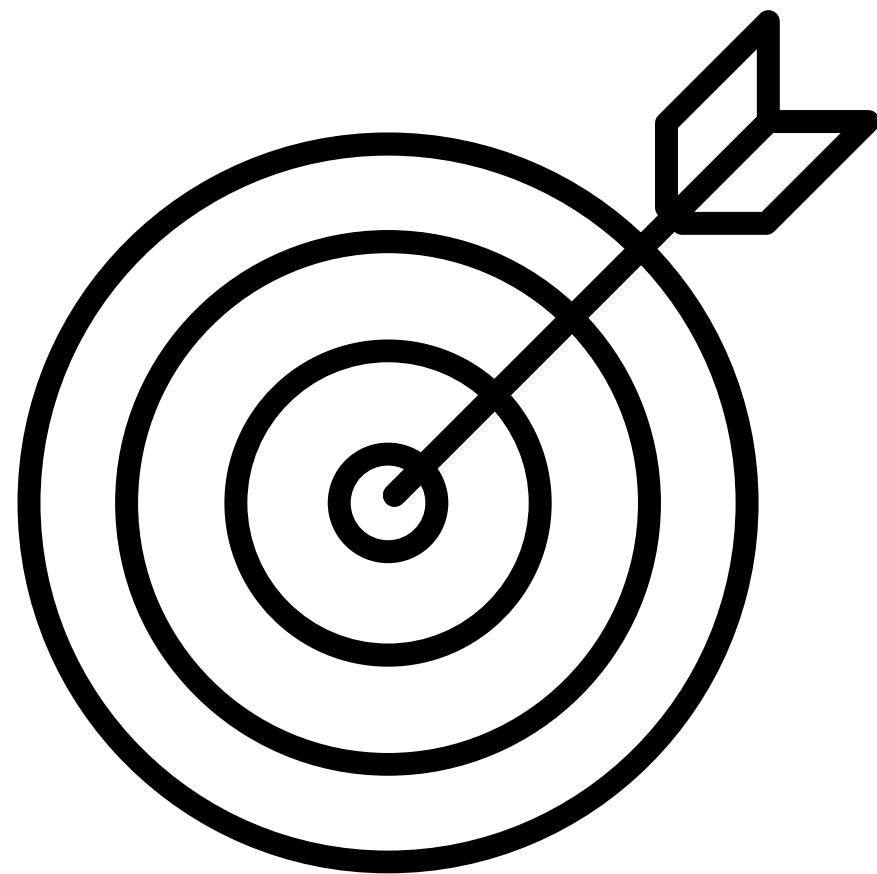


I'm **Cynthia Heider**, the Public Digital Scholarship Librarian at Penn Libraries.

I can help with:

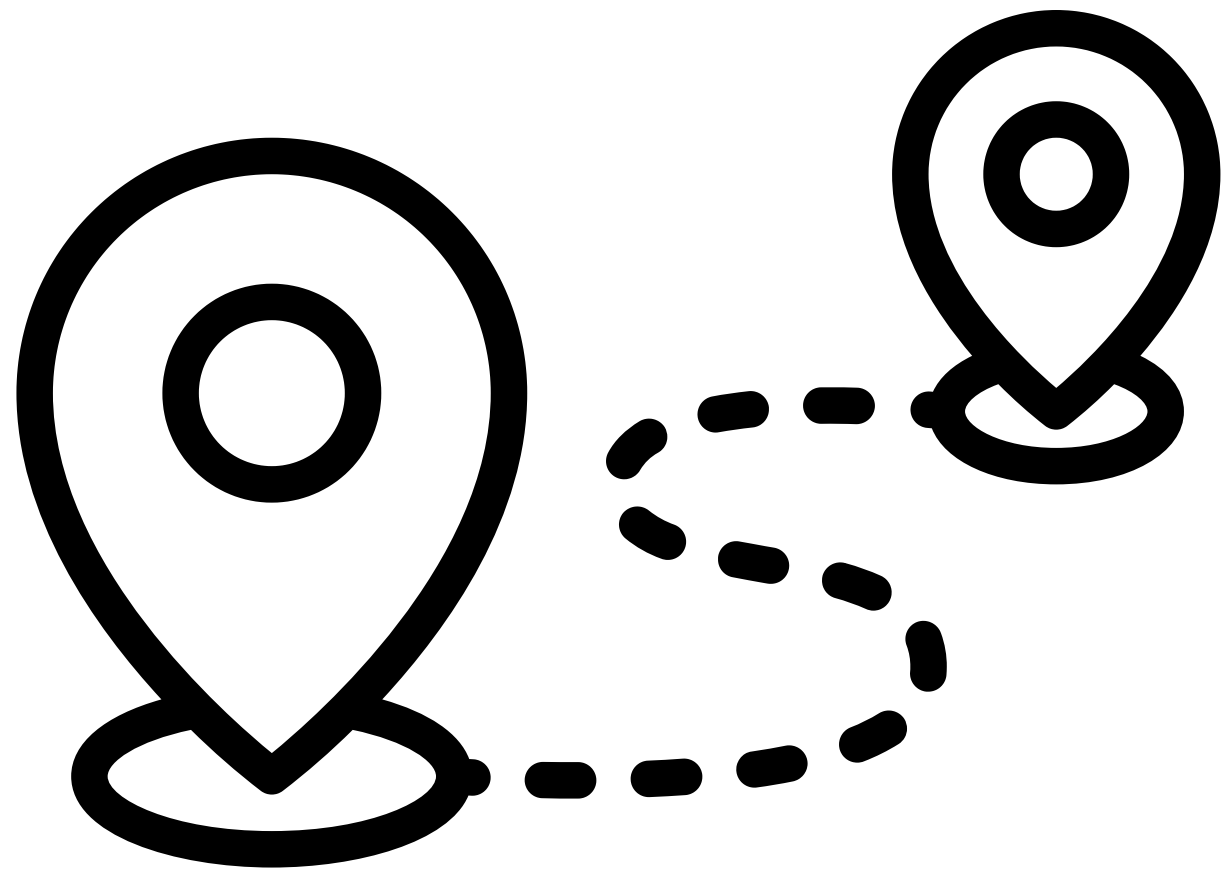
- Digital projects for public audiences
- Digital projects involving community partners
- Choosing the right tool or platform for your digital project
- Working with data in the humanities
- Connecting with digital project resources at and beyond UPenn

Workshop goals



- Define (“squishy”) digital humanities and what it can offer educators
- Identify some of the methods used in digital humanities and how they could be incorporated in coursework
- Try out some tools for yourself!
- Identify what evaluation might look like for digital humanities assignments

Workshop Roadmap & Scope



- define digital humanities and its affordances
- introduce four common methods used in DH and examples, popular tools, and sample assignments associated with them
- practice with a tool for each method
- discuss assessment and grading of DH assignments

This is an entry point!

What's digital humanities?

Definitions

What Is Digital Humanities?

New quote

Who the hell knows....I certainly don't **Ethan Watrall**

NB: Click the [New quote](#) button to display a new random quote. Quotes were pulled from participants from the [Day of DH](#) between 2009-2014. As of January 2015, the database contains 817 rows and randomly selects a quote each time the page is loaded. If you want to do something cool with the data, I am providing the code and data [here](#).

Made by [Jason Heppler](#). Problems? Questions? I'm [@jaheppler](#) on Twitter.

In brief

“Digital humanities is born of the encounter between traditional humanities and computational methods.”

In practice

- Mapping, data analysis, parsing lots of text
 - Digital exhibits, digital archives, podcasts, VR
 - Communicating information
-

Just for fun

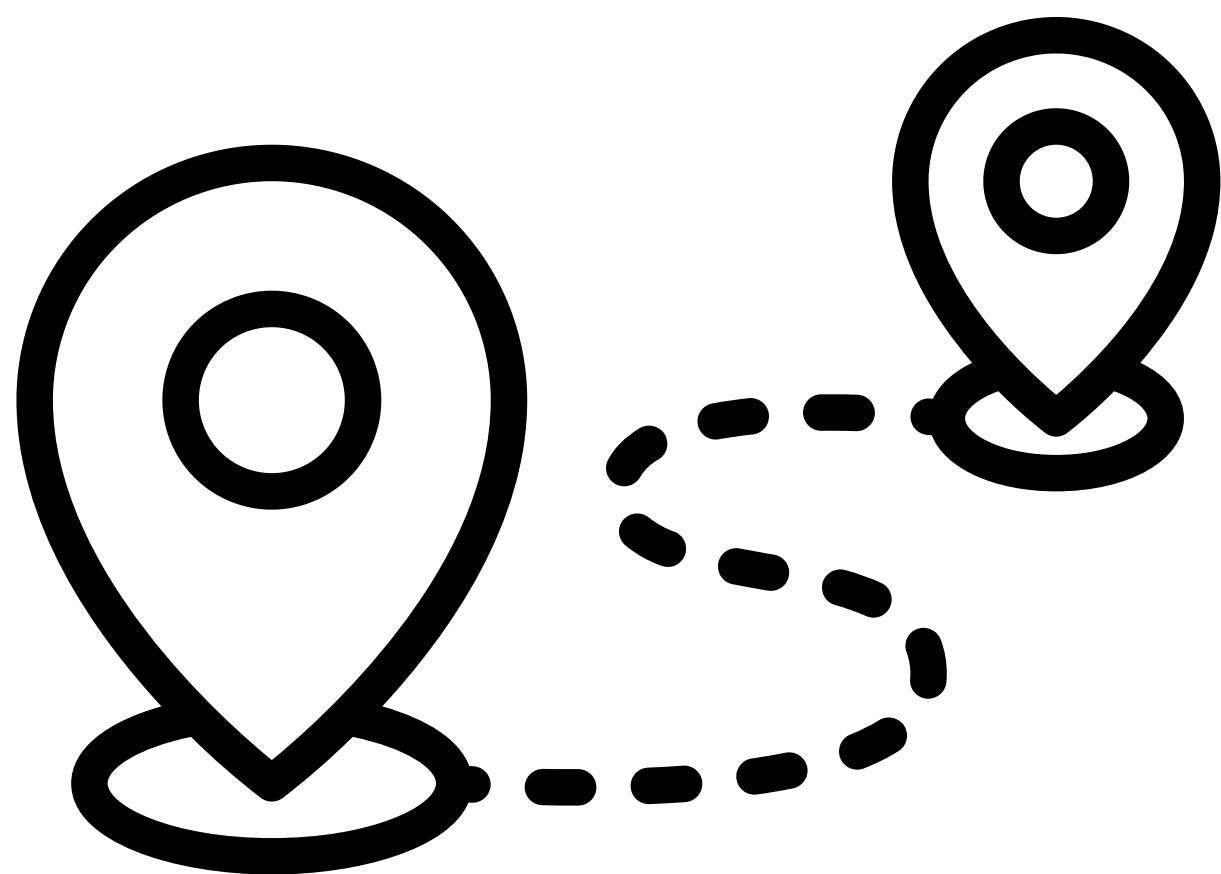
<https://whatisdigitalhumanities.com/>

Domains

- Research
 - Analysis
 - Interpretation
 - Experimentation
-

Why do digital humanities?

What the digital humanities can do



- Exploring research materials with different tools can lead to different research questions and/or deeper insights and understanding of materials
- Collaborative approaches to teaching and learning, as well as performing and sharing research
- Honing “scholarly communication” skills and increasing public impact
- Learning from the process of doing

Choosing how to incorporate DH

One-off
assignments

Sustained
projects

Team-
based

Individual

Tool or
method
competency

Topic
competency

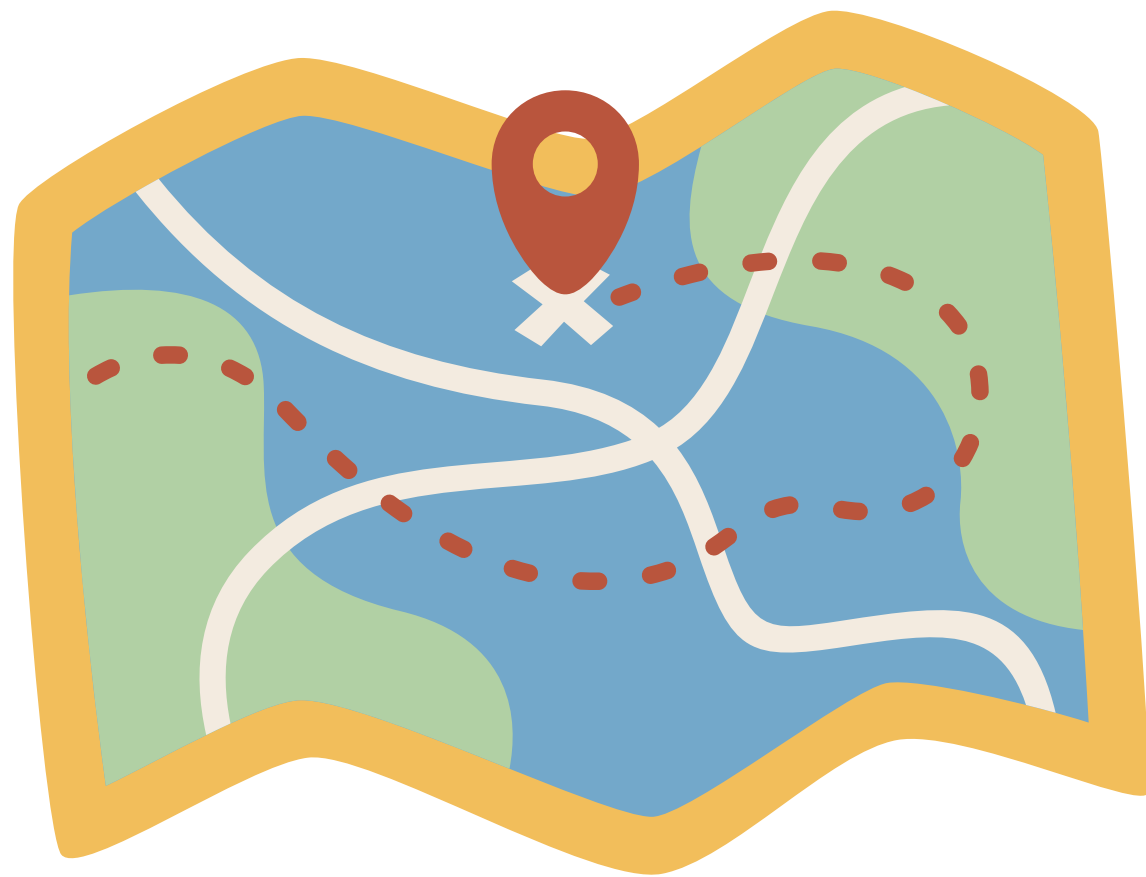
New
assignments

Repurposed
assignments



Methods & tools

Mapping



Definition

Evaluation and interpretation of spatial data

- how do we understand and tell stories about place and space?

Examples

- [Boston's Black Heritage Trail](#)
- [Mapping Inequality: Redlining in New Deal America](#)

Popular Tools

- [Google MyMaps](#)
- [Clio](#) (walking tours)
- [StoryMapJS](#)
- [ArcGIS/QGIS](#)

Sample assignments

- [From Text to Interactive Image: A Digital Mapping Project \(Rubric\)](#)
- [Nineteenth-Century Slave Narratives - Building a Digital Story Map \(p.95\)](#)

Activity: StoryMapJS

1. Navigate to <https://storymap.knightlab.com/> and “Make a StoryMap”
2. Sign in with Google and create a new project
3. Pick two of your favorite restaurants. Add info for each restaurant on its own slide.
4. Share the link to your StoryMap in the chat if you wish!

Take 7 minutes!

I'll give a 1 minute warning



Data visualization



Definition

Analyzing and displaying information visually

- make sense of large sets of data
 - discovery of larger patterns
-

Popular Tools

- [Connect the Dots](#)
 - [Palladio](#)
 - [Flourish](#)
 - [Datawrapper](#)
-

Examples

- [In the Same Boats](#)
 - [Viral Texts](#)
-

Sample assignments

- [Visualizing the Census](#)
 - [Building a Network Diagram](#)
 - [Deconstruct a Data Viz](#)
 - [Remix an Infographic](#)
-

Activity: Connect the Dots

1. Navigate to https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1dCDx8Ej_-MvVmrWFEwAliLEPRkN7jCsoJ6xeCGMeaHs/edit?usp=sharing (don't worry, I'll paste it in the chat!)
2. Fill out two rows in the spreadsheet, one for each of your favorite restaurants
3. When everyone is finished, copy the data
4. Navigate to <https://databasic.io/connectthedots>
5. Paste the data into the "Paste Data" tab and click on "Graph"



Take 3 minutes!

I'll give a 1 minute warning

Text analysis



Definition

Read bodies of text in new ways to pick up on word frequency patterns in texts

- uses machine learning, which powers most generative AI

Examples

- [Hedonometer](#)
- [Mining the Dispatch](#)

Popular Tools

- Voyant Tools
- [Google N-gram Viewer](#)
- [MALLET](#)

Sample assignments

- [Novel Analysis](#)
- [Reading at Scale: Teaching with Voyant, a Digital Humanities Tool](#) (p.61)
- [Sketch a Data Story](#)

Demo: Voyant Tools

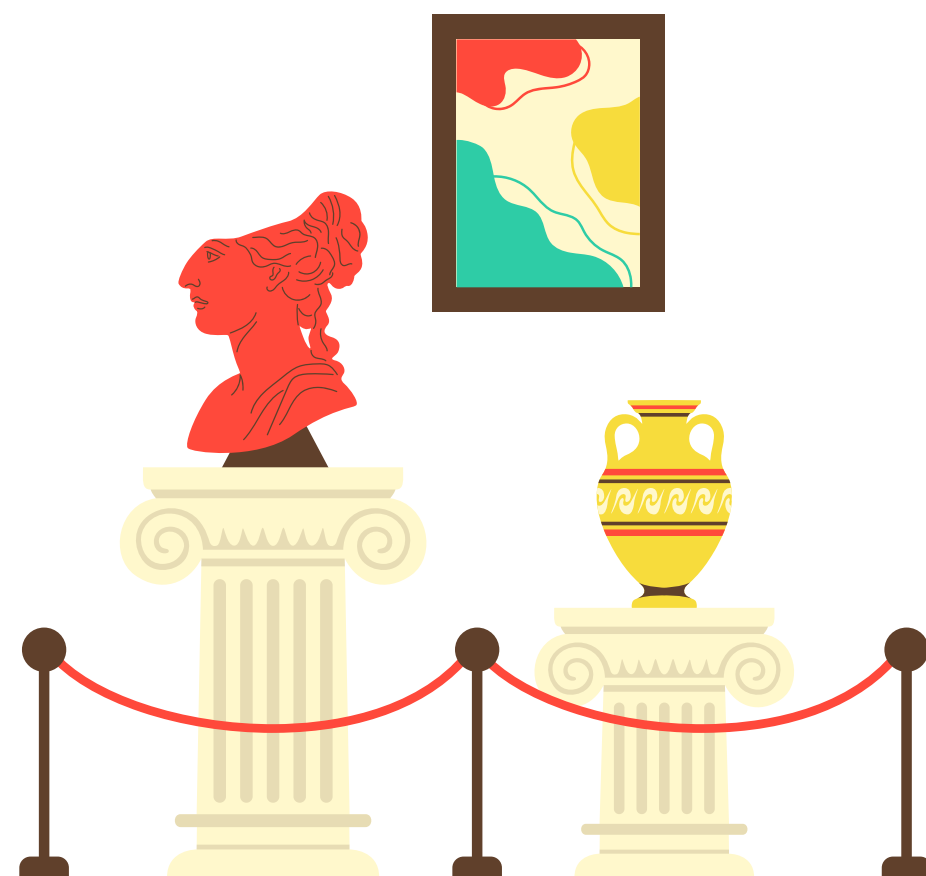
Voyant's server can get overloaded if too many people are using it at the exact same time, so I'm going to demo it instead of going through an activity.

Elements of a Voyant analysis:

- Cirrus: a kind of word cloud showing the most frequent terms
- Reader: an efficient corpus reader that fetches segments of text as you scroll
- Trends: a distribution graph showing terms across the corpus (or terms within a document)
- Summary: a tool that provides a simple, textual overview of the current corpus
- Contexts: a concordance that shows each occurrence of a keyword with a bit of surrounding context



Digital storytelling



Definition

Combining elements of many modalities to compare, analyze and display items in context

- think podcasts, digital editions, exhibits, archives
-

Examples

- [What Jane Saw](#)
 - [A Civil Rights Turning Point](#)
 - [The Jane Addams Digital Edition](#)
-

Popular Tools

- [Rondo](#)
 - [Omeka](#)
 - [Scalar](#)
 - [ArcGIS StoryMaps](#)
-

Sample assignments

- [DIY Digital Edition \(Rubric\)](#)
 - [Basic Podcasting Assignment](#)
 - [StoryMaps Assignment Building](#)
-

Activity: Rondo

1. Make a copy of the Rondo template at <https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1iwlx8sqiBTqbtAI7TX4vDGDVee3dPz0wa3MazBv2fzQ/copy> (don't worry, I'll paste it in the chat!)
2. Choose an image from the DPLA collections on "tree" (at <https://dp.la/search?q=tree>)
3. Fill out the last column in the spreadsheet with your image's information
4. Enter your spreadsheet ID and shareable URL at <https://sjsu-library.github.io/rondo/?page=builder>. **The spreadsheet ID is the long string of characters located between /d/ and /edit.**



Take 7 minutes!

I'll give a 1 minute warning

Assessment & grading

Assessment considerations

Your assessment should be drawn **primarily** from the goals of the course, not from a student's level of mastery over technology (unless that is one of your learning goals)

Integration with learning goals

Scaffolding

Failure as pedagogy



Grading

Assignments should make clear exactly what parts of the project are important to student evaluation. Determine and communicate whether the emphasis is on the process or the aesthetics/usability of the end product.

Rubrics

Role of iteration and experimentation

Project components



Resources

[Using digital humanities in the classroom : a practical introduction for teachers, lecturers, and students](#)
(Battershill)

[Digital humanities pedagogy: practices, principles and politics](#)
(Hirsch)

[Doing Digital Humanities and Social Sciences in Your Classroom](#)
(Cutrara)

[Digital Pedagogy in the Humanities: Concepts, Models, and Experiments](#)

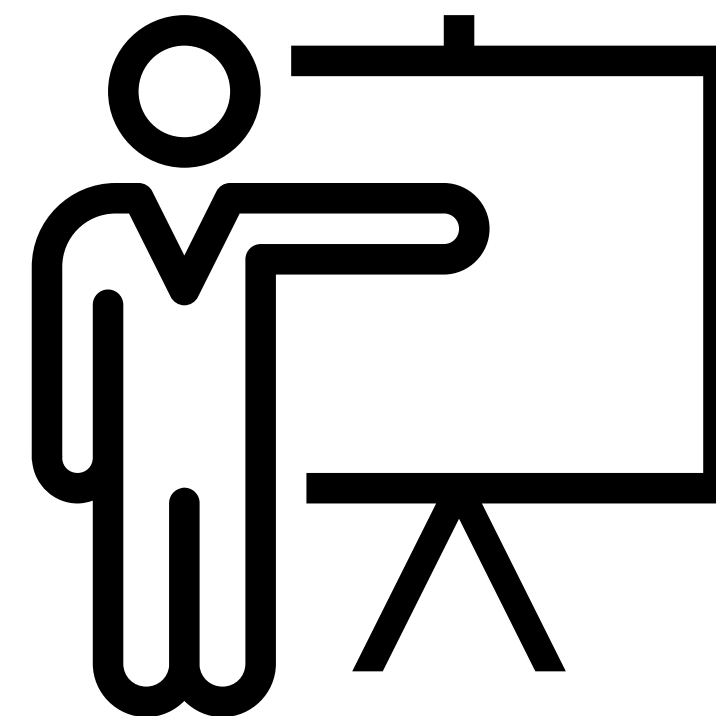
[Digital Pedagogy in the Humanities video lectures](#)

[Digital Pedagogy Institute](#)

[Digital Humanities Summer Institute](#)

[The Programming Historian](#)

[Dream Lab \(Price Lab for Digital Humanities\)](#)



Thank You

Please don't hesitate to reach out!

Cynthia Heider

Public Digital Scholarship Librarian at Penn Libraries

heider@upenn.edu

<https://www.library.upenn.edu/staff/cynthia-heider>

Survey



https://upenn.libwizard.com/f/rdds_survey_sp2026